

EYEWITNESS April 12, 1861

Fort Sumter

After years of swirling debates and threats, the first shots of the Civil War echoed across South Carolina's Charleston Harbor on April 12, 1861. When Major Robert Anderson refused to surrender Fort Sumter to General P. G. T. Beauregard, Confederate batteries opened fire upon the provision-depleted fort. Fort Sumter surrendered 34 hours later, and the Civil War began.

"By 11 a.m. the conflagration was terrible and disastrous. One-fifth of the fort was on fire, and the wind drove the smoke in dense masses into the angle where we had all taken refuge. It seemed impossible to escape suffocation. Some lay down close to the ground, with handkerchiefs over their mouths ... every one suffered severely ... the scene at this time was really terrific. The roaring and crackling of the flames, the dense masses of whirling smoke, the bursting of the enemy's shells, and our own which were exploding in the burning rooms, the crashing of the shot, and the sound of masonry falling in every direction, made the fort a pandemonium. When at last nothing was left of the building but the blackened walls and smoldering embers, it became painfully evident that an immense amount of damage had been done ... about 12:48 p.m. the end of the flag-staff was shot down, and the flag fell."

ABNER DOUBLEDAY, CAPTAIN OF COMPANY E, 1ST UNITED STATES ARTILLERY, FROM *REMINISCENCES OF FORTS SUMTER AND MOULTRIE 1860-61*. DOUBLEDAY GAVE THE ORDER TO FIRE THE FIRST GUN IN THE DEFENSE OF FORT SUMTER

"Thank God! Thank God! The day has come; the war is open, and we will conquer or perish. We have defeated their twenty millions, and we have humbled the proud flag of the Stars and Stripes that never before lowered to any nation on earth. We have lowered it in humility before the Palmetto and Confederate flags, and have compelled them to raise a white flag and ask for honorable surrender. The Stars and Stripes have triumphed for 70 years, but on this 13th of April it has been humbled by the little State of South Carolina. And I pronounce here, before the civilized world, that your independence is